

Q Will I be able to stay with my baby all the time?

You will need to check the policy in your hospital, but most hospitals allow parents to stay with their baby as long as they want throughout the day and night. Being close to you, hearing you, and being caressed by you are all ways in which you can help your baby gain strength. Keep in mind, though, that you and your partner need to rest, and that your body needs to recover from birth. You may have been faced with difficult decisions and have had to deal with the unexpected circumstances of your baby's arrival in the world; though you may feel guilt if you're not with your baby the whole time, some time away from the NICU, both together and separately, is important for your well-being.

Q Can other family members and friends visit my premature baby?

Most neonatal intensive care units will allow a few visitors at a time, and siblings in particular are encouraged to come and bond with their new brother or sister. The ward will, though, have specific visiting times for visitors, whereas parents usually can stay around the clock. Keep in mind that too many people at one time can be overwhelming, so try to keep visitor numbers small at any one time. Don't feel obligated to run an open house; you have a lot to contend with so if you prefer just immediate family to visit for the time being, this is fine. Premature babies have low immunity, so anyone who has an infection, such as a cold, will be encouraged to stay away until they are completely recovered.

Q When will we be able to take our baby home?

The circumstances of every baby's special-care needs are different, and so how long your baby remains in the NICU entirely depends on his health at birth and his reasons for needing special care. In general, hospitals will recommend that premature babies stay in the NICU at least until they have reached "full term." At this stage, your baby's organs should be well developed enough that he can manage the demands of life outside the incubator.

In general, before your baby is ready to be go home, the NICU will want to ensure that he fulfills a number of criteria. First, staff needs to be confident that your baby can breathe independently, which happens in stages. As he grows stronger, the nurses will take him off the ventilation equipment for short periods of time so that he can practice breathing for himself. Gradually, the amount of time your baby spends getting help with his breathing will decrease, until he can breathe fully on his own.

In addition to being able to breathe independently, the staff wants to see that your baby is feeding well—whether breast- or formula feeding—and gaining weight, and that he is urinating and passing stools regularly and without difficulty.

When you do leave, you may be given a follow-up appointment at the hospital in a few weeks time to check your baby's progress.

Q How can I prepare to take over the care of my baby?

Before you take your baby home, the nursing staff will make sure you are confident about administering his medication (see box, below) and that you have support systems in place to ensure you get all the help (personal and professional) you need to take care of your baby. Some hospitals ask you to stay overnight with your baby just before you take him home so you can follow his 24-hour pattern of care with help on hand if you need it. It's natural to be nervous when your baby has been so closely monitored in the hospital, but remind yourself that the hospital is happy for him to leave since they are confident that you will be able to take care of him independently now, and that home is the best place for him to grow and thrive.

Q I'm worried about administering my baby's medicines. Are there any tips or techniques I should know?

The neonatal nurses in the NICU will try to make sure you're confident about administering your baby's medicines while your baby is in the NICU so that you can continue when at home. However, inevitably when you get home, without their watchful guidance, giving medicine can feel overwhelming. The following tips, techniques, and guidance can increase your confidence:

» **First and foremost** try to stay calm, because your baby will pick up on your stress and in turn will be less relaxed himself. Eye drops, nose drops, vitamins, minerals, and medicines all come in easy-to-administer liquid form for babies.

» **Try to avoid** any part of the medicine bottle, for example the eye drop pipette, or the tip of a bottle of nasal drops, touching your baby's skin. If you do, don't worry—just wipe the tip with an antibacterial wipe before you use it again.

» **Most importantly, always wash your hands** before giving your baby any medicine. Shake any medicines before you give them, and have everything you might need, such as antibacterial wipes or cotton pads, within easy reach.

» **Swaddle your baby** so that his arms and legs stay still, then place him on his back on the floor or cradle him in one arm, depending upon whether you need one or two hands to give the medicine (for eye drops, you'll need two hands, for example).

» **If your baby becomes distressed,** stop what you're doing and calm him before trying again. Never miss a dose of medicine, though, unless your doctor says that it's okay to.

» **Make a wall chart** to remind you when to give which medicines, and check them off each day so that you don't have to rely upon your memory.

» **Keep in mind that at home** you will follow the same medication routine that your baby had during his stay in the hospital, which at first can provide a helpful pattern for your day.

